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NCE Predicted Examination Paper — 2026

2026

ENGLISH

GRADE 9 • PAPER 4 OF 4

Time Allowed: **2 hours 15 minutes**

Total Marks: **100**

Candidate Name: _____

School: _____

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES

1. Read all instructions carefully before you begin.
2. Answer **ALL** questions in Sections A, B and D.
3. In Section C (Writing), answer **ONE** task only.
4. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
5. The marks available for each question are shown in a box [].
6. Use blue or black ink. Pencil may be used for diagrams only.
7. Dictionaries are **not** permitted.

Section	Topic	Available	Obtained
A	Reading Comprehension	30	
B	Language Use	25	
C	Writing	30	
D	Vocabulary & Word Study	15	
TOTAL		100	

SECTION A — READING COMPREHENSION [30 marks]

Read the passage carefully, then answer **ALL** the questions that follow.

More Than the Absence of Illness: Rethinking Health and Wellbeing in Teenagers

For much of the twentieth century, health was understood primarily as the absence of disease. A person was considered healthy if they were not suffering from a physical illness, and the role of medicine was to treat those who fell sick. Today, however, this narrow definition has been largely replaced by a broader and more nuanced understanding: that genuine health encompasses not only physical fitness, but also mental, emotional, and social wellbeing. For teenagers in particular, this holistic view is not merely desirable — it is essential.

Adolescence is a period of remarkable transformation. The brain undergoes significant development during the teenage years, with the prefrontal cortex — the region responsible for planning, decision-making, and impulse control — not fully maturing until the mid-twenties. This makes teenagers uniquely vulnerable to stress, peer pressure, and risky behaviour, but also uniquely receptive to positive influences. The habits formed during adolescence — whether around diet, exercise, sleep, or emotional regulation — often persist well into adulthood.

Sleep is perhaps the most underestimated factor in teenage health. Research consistently shows that adolescents require between eight and ten hours of sleep per night, yet surveys indicate that the majority get far less. Chronic sleep deprivation in teenagers has been linked to poor academic performance, heightened emotional reactivity, impaired immune function, and an increased risk of obesity and depression. Despite this evidence, many schools continue to schedule lessons as early as seven-thirty in the morning — a practice that some health experts now consider harmful.

Physical activity is equally important. The World Health Organisation recommends that children and teenagers engage in at least sixty minutes of moderate-to-vigorous physical activity each day. Regular exercise not only strengthens the heart and muscles, but also releases endorphins — the brain's natural mood-enhancing chemicals — and has been shown to reduce symptoms of anxiety and depression. Yet screen-based entertainment and academic pressure have led to a dramatic decline in the physical activity levels of young people worldwide.

Addressing teenage health effectively requires action at every level: from individual choices about diet and rest, to school policies that prioritise student wellbeing, to government investment in sports facilities, mental health services, and health education. Above all, it requires a cultural shift in the way we talk about health — moving away from quick fixes and physical appearance, and towards a genuine, sustained commitment to young people's long-term flourishing.

1. How was health understood for much of the twentieth century, according to the passage?

[1]

2. According to paragraph 2, what is the prefrontal cortex and why is its development significant for teenagers?

[2]

3. List **THREE** consequences of chronic sleep deprivation in teenagers, as stated in paragraph 3.

[3]

(a)

(b)

(c)

4. What does the word "*holistic*" (paragraph 1) mean as used in the context of the passage? How does the passage justify this approach to health?

[2]

5. Find a word in **paragraph 2** that means "*continuing or lasting into the future.*"

[1]

6. Find a word in **paragraph 4** that means "*natural chemicals produced by the brain that improve mood.*"

[1]

7. Why does the writer suggest that the hours at which schools start lessons may be harmful? Use evidence from the passage.

[2]

8. According to the passage, what are the benefits of regular physical activity for teenagers? Why, despite this, do many teenagers not get enough exercise? [4]

9. In the final paragraph, the writer argues for action "at every level." Explain what this means, identifying the three levels of action the writer mentions, and evaluate how convincing you find this conclusion. [4]

10. *"Schools have a greater responsibility for students' health and wellbeing than parents do."* [10]

Do you agree? Use **evidence from the passage** and your **own ideas** to support your answer. Write approximately 150–200 words.

SECTION B — LANGUAGE USE [25 marks]

Answer **ALL** questions in this section.

Part 1 — Active and Passive Voice [5 marks]

Rewrite each sentence by changing from **active to passive** or **passive to active** as instructed. Do **not** change the tense.

11. *Health professionals have linked chronic sleep deprivation to serious long-term consequences.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

12. *A new mental health programme was introduced by the Ministry of Education last term.* [Change to **active**] [1]

13. *The school canteen is serving healthier meal options this year.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

14. *The new sports facilities will be funded entirely by the government.* [Change to **active**] [1]

15. *Researchers are conducting a national survey on teenage mental health.* [Change to **passive**] [1]

Part 2 — Reported Speech [5 marks]

Change each sentence into **reported speech**. Begin with the words given.

16. *"Teenagers need at least eight hours of sleep every night," said the doctor.* [1]
The doctor said _____
17. *"I will start an after-school sports programme next term," the headteacher promised.* [1]
The headteacher promised _____
18. *"Are you getting enough sleep and exercise?" the nurse asked the student.* [1]
The nurse asked the student _____
19. *"You must not skip meals, especially breakfast," the nutritionist advised the teenager.* [1]
The nutritionist advised the teenager _____
20. *"Exercise releases chemicals in the brain that naturally improve your mood," the psychologist explained.* [1]
The psychologist explained _____

Part 3 — Conditionals [5 marks]

Complete each sentence using the correct form of the verb in brackets.

21. If teenagers _____ (sleep) for at least eight hours each night, they would perform better at school. (2nd conditional) [1]
22. If the school _____ (start) lessons later in the morning, many students would arrive feeling more alert and ready to learn. (2nd conditional) [1]
23. If the government had built more sports facilities in this area, fewer children _____ (become) sedentary. (3rd conditional) [1]
24. Unless teenagers _____ (limit) their screen time in the evenings, their sleep quality will continue to deteriorate. [1]
25. She would not have suffered from such poor health had she _____ (eat) a balanced diet from an early age. (3rd conditional) [1]

Part 4 — Connectives [5 marks]

Choose the most appropriate connective from the box to complete each sentence. Each word is used **once only**.

26. Regular physical activity strengthens the heart and muscles; _____, it improves mood and reduces anxiety. [1]
27. _____ the increasing availability of junk food near schools, poor nutrition has become a serious public health concern. [1]
28. Exercise is not a luxury; _____, for many young people it is a vital part of maintaining good mental health. [1]
29. Students can take part in the lunchtime running club _____ they have written permission from a parent or guardian. [1]
30. Teenagers will continue to thrive physically and mentally _____ they are given the right support, information, and opportunities. [1]

Part 5 — Tenses [5 marks]

Fill in each blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets.

31. By the time she reached the age of eighteen, she _____ (exercise) regularly for over six years. [1]
32. The school _____ (introduce) a new mindfulness programme next September. [1]
33. He _____ (study) for his exams for five hours when his mother insisted he take a break. [1]
34. Research shows that the number of teenagers diagnosed with anxiety _____ (rise) steadily since the mid-2010s. [1]
35. The health committee _____ (currently / review) the guidelines on recommended daily sugar intake for young people. [1]

SECTION C — WRITING [30 marks]

Choose **ONE** task only. Write between **250 and 350 words**. Plan your answer before you write.

TASK A — Formal Letter

Write a **formal letter** to the Principal of your school arguing that the school day should begin later to improve student health and academic performance. Your letter should refer to evidence about sleep and adolescent development, propose specific changes, and address likely objections.

TASK B — Discursive Essay

Write a **discursive essay** with the title: *"Young people today are less healthy than previous generations."* Present evidence and arguments on both sides before reaching a justified conclusion based on your own view.

TASK C — Creative Writing

Write a **short story** in which the main character makes a decision that significantly improves their physical or mental health. Show, through their thoughts and feelings, how this decision changes their life. Use dialogue and descriptive language to bring your story to life.

Task chosen (circle): **A** **B** **C**

SECTION D — VOCABULARY AND WORD STUDY [15 marks]

Part 1 — Phrasal Verbs [5 marks]

Replace the underlined words or phrase in each sentence with the correct phrasal verb from the box. Do **not** change the form of the verb.

burn out | cut out | take up | build up | come down with

36. After months of studying with no rest, she finally became completely exhausted and had to take two weeks off school. [1]

Answer: _____

37. The doctor advised him to stop eating sugary snacks and fizzy drinks entirely. [1]

Answer: _____

38. She decided to start doing yoga three times a week to manage her stress more effectively. [1]

Answer: _____

39. Fitness experts recommend that beginners gradually increase the intensity of their workouts over several weeks. [1]

Answer: _____

40. He became ill with a severe cold just two days before his final examinations. [1]

Answer: _____

Part 2 — Word Forms [5 marks]

Complete the table by writing the missing word form in each **shaded cell**. One mark per correct answer.

Verb	Noun	Adjective
nourish		nourishing / nourished
	prevention	preventable / preventive
recover	recovery	
	strength	strong
deprive		deprived

[5 marks: 1 mark per shaded cell]

Part 3 — Vocabulary in Context [5 marks]

Choose the word (A, B, or C) that best completes each sentence. The meaning must fit the context precisely.

41. Good sleep is _____ to a teenager's academic performance, emotional stability, and physical health. [1]
A. secondary B. vital C. optional
42. The survey found a strong _____ between the amount of time teenagers spend on screens and their reported levels of anxiety. [1]
A. link B. join C. bridge
43. Regular physical activity has been shown to _____ symptoms of depression and anxiety in young people. [1]
A. heighten B. increase C. reduce
44. Teenagers who eat a balanced diet tend to be more _____ to illness during exam season than those who rely on processed food. [1]
A. resistant B. sensitive C. addicted
45. The government has pledged to _____ funding for mental health services in secondary schools by thirty percent next year. [1]
A. decrease B. increase C. maintain

MARK SCHEME — Paper 4 (Health / Wellbeing)

For teacher / examiner use. Accept any answer clearly correct in meaning. Where own words are required, do not award marks for direct quotation unless stated. Apply the writing grid for Q10 and Section C.

Q	Acceptable Answer(s)	Mark
1	Health was understood as the absence of disease / illness. A person was considered healthy if they were not suffering from a physical illness.	1
2	The prefrontal cortex is the part of the brain responsible for planning, decision-making, and impulse control. Its significance: it does not fully mature until the mid-twenties, making teenagers especially vulnerable to stress and risky behaviour but also open to positive influences. (1 mark: what it is; 1 mark: why this matters for teenagers.)	2
3	Any three from: poor academic performance; heightened emotional reactivity; impaired immune function; increased risk of obesity; increased risk of depression. (1 mark each.)	3
4	Holistic means looking at health as a whole — including physical, mental, emotional, and social wellbeing, not just the absence of physical illness. The passage justifies this by arguing that for teenagers, all these aspects are interconnected and essential. (1 mark: correct meaning; 1 mark: justification from passage.)	2
5	persist	1
6	endorphins	1
7	The writer points out that adolescents need 8–10 hours of sleep, yet many get far less. Starting school as early as 7:30 am forces students to wake up too early, depriving them of the sleep they need — a practice some health experts now consider harmful. (1 mark for the sleep requirement; 1 mark for linking early start to sleep deprivation.)	2
8	Benefits [2 marks]: Strengthens heart and muscles; releases endorphins that improve mood; reduces anxiety and depression. (Award 2 marks for any two, clearly explained.) Reasons for insufficient exercise [2 marks]: Screen-based entertainment competes for time; academic pressure leaves less time; accept other reasonable inferences from the passage. Total: 4 marks.	4
9	Three levels [3 marks]: (1) Individual — personal choices around diet and rest. (2) School — policies that prioritise student wellbeing. (3) Government — investment in sports facilities, mental health services, health education. (1 mark each.) Evaluation [1 mark]: credit any reasonable, supported response — e.g. the conclusion is convincing because it is comprehensive / realistic / acknowledges shared responsibility. Total: 4 marks.	4
10	Extended response grid (10 marks): Content & argument [4]: Addresses the statement directly;	10

	uses passage evidence; adds own ideas; takes a clear position. Organisation [3]: Clear intro and conclusion; logical paragraphing; effective connectives. Language [3]: Accurate grammar and spelling; varied vocabulary; appropriate discursive register.	
Section B — Language Use		
11	Chronic sleep deprivation has been linked to serious long-term consequences by health professionals.	1
12	The Ministry of Education introduced a new mental health programme last term.	1
13	Healthier meal options are being served by the school canteen this year.	1
14	The government will fund the new sports facilities entirely.	1
15	A national survey on teenage mental health is being conducted by researchers.	1
16	The doctor said (that) teenagers needed at least eight hours of sleep every night.	1
17	The headteacher promised (that) he/she would start an after-school sports programme the following term / next term.	1
18	The nurse asked the student if / whether he/she was getting enough sleep and exercise.	1
19	The nutritionist advised the teenager not to skip meals, especially breakfast.	1
20	The psychologist explained (that) exercise releases / released chemicals in the brain that naturally improve / improved mood.	1
21	slept	1
22	started	1
23	would not have become	1
24	limit	1
25	eaten	1
26	moreover	1
27	Owing to	1
28	on the contrary	1
29	provided that	1
30	as long as	1
31	had been exercising	1
32	will introduce / is going to introduce	1
33	had been studying	1
34	has been rising	1
35	is currently reviewing	1

Section C — Writing (30 marks)		
C	Content & Task Fulfilment [12]: Task fully addressed; correct form; sufficient detail and development. Organisation & Structure [9]: Clear introduction and conclusion; logical paragraphing; effective connectives. Language & Style [9]: Accurate grammar, punctuation and spelling; varied sentences and vocabulary; appropriate register.	30
Section D — Vocabulary & Word Study		
36	burned out (burnt out)	1
37	cut out	1
38	take up	1
39	build up	1
40	came down with	1
Word forms	Row 1: nourishment . Row 2: prevent . Row 3: recovered / recoverable . Row 4: strengthen . Row 5: deprivation .	5
41	B — vital	1
42	A — link	1
43	C — reduce	1
44	A — resistant	1
45	B — increase	1